



SYLLABUS FOR MGMT 827-1: FinTech

(This version: March 17th, 2026)

Course Changes:

This syllabus is a guideline for the course. I will do my best to conduct the course according to the schedule and policies outlined in this syllabus. I reserve the right to adjust the course (e.g., schedule, assignments, etc.) as we proceed as I see fit. Please refer to Canvas for the latest syllabus and any course changes.

Teaching Team:

Professor Benedict Guttman-Kenney

E-mail: benedictgk@rice.edu (please re-send if you do not hear from me in 24 hours)

Teaching Assistant: Amy Chen Qian

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Faculty Support Specialist: Luis Leyva

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Phone: 713-348-5326

Classes:

Tuesdays from 6.15pm to 9.30pm in McNair 314.

Office Hours:

Please email Amy for an appointment.

Make an appointment with Benedict on [Calendly](https://calendly.com/benedictgk). If no times listed match your availability, please email me.

I highly recommend emailing questions in advance to make the meeting most productive.

Objective:

This course studies the topic of “FinTech,” the innovative use of technology in financial services. We cover the use of machine learning (ML) and artificial intelligence (AI) in FinTech lending and the information problems that FinTech firms face, payment systems, decentralized finance (“DeFi”) and crypto topics such as blockchain and bitcoin, and how social media and networks impact financial outcomes. It is an applied course, using cases to understand FinTech business models, the economic opportunities for these firms, and the challenges that they face.

If you are interested in these topics, I highly recommend also taking Manolo Sanchez’s ILE short course “The Money Revolution: Digital Disruption in Finance,” which features high-profile speakers and complements my class.

Canvas:

All materials for this course will be available via Canvas. This should be your first stop if you are looking for information.

Course Outline:

You are expected to read the assigned cases before class and come prepared to discuss them. Each week, slides are posted during class, once we have discussed the case assignment.

Week	Topics
Week 1: March 17 th	Introduction & Machine Learning (ML) in FinTech
Week 2: March 24 th	FinTech Lending & Information Asymmetries Guest Speaker: Abby Wood, Chief Strategy Officer at Arro Case Discussion: “Upstart’s Upshot: Is Fintech Lending Fair?” Assignment 1 (Upstart) due: 6pm before class
Week 3: March 31 st	Artificial Intelligence (AI) in FinTech Case Discussion: “Zillow Offers: Winning Online Real Estate 2.0” Assignment 2 (Zillow) due: 6pm before class
Week 4: April 7 th	Payment Systems Case Discussion: “Lemonade: Disrupting Insurance with Instant Everything, Killer Prices, and a Big Heart” Case Discussion: “The Quest for Achieving Financial Inclusion: M-Pesa Versus UPI” Assignment 3 (Lemonade & M-Pesa) due: 6pm before class
Week 5: April 14 th	Blockchain, Crypto, & Decentralized Finance (DeFi) Assignment 4 (Lending Club) due: 6pm before class
Week 6: April 21 st	Social Interactions in Financial Markets Case Discussion: “GameStop: Social Media Finds a Cheat Code (A)” Assignment 5 (GameStop) due: 6pm before class
	Assignment 6 (Final Project) due: 11.59pm Wednesday April 28th

Graded Assignments	Weight
Assignments (1 to 5)	60%
Participation	20%
Final Project (Assignment 6)	20%
Total	100%

Assignments 1 to 5 and the final project (Assignment 6) can all be done in groups of no more than four students. It is also fine to do the final project individually if you prefer.

There is no exam.

Your class letter grade is ultimately determined following the Jones School grading policy for elective courses. This requires that the GPA must be between 3.50 and 3.80.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy:

The abilities of AI tools such as ChatGPT are rapidly developing. AI tools can assist learning, but they also commonly make basic mistakes.

You may use AI tools to review concepts learnt in class and for any graded assignments. If you use AI tools, you need to include a disclaimer on how you used it. If I suspect you used AI tools without acknowledgement you will receive a 0.

You may not upload any case materials to AI tools, as this is a breach of copyright: “The use of any materials for training or inputting into generative AI technologies or LLMs without expressed written permission from the copyright holder is strictly prohibited.” <https://hbsp.harvard.edu/copyright-permission/>

Grading Policy:

1. Late assignments are **never** accepted for credit **unless** both (i) there are extenuating circumstances, and (ii) I have granted permission **prior to the due date**.

Participation:

You are expected to be on time and seated when class starts. Late arrivals disrupt class, and this will be reflected heavily in your participation grade. **If possible, wait for breaks or the end of class to leave to minimize disruptions.**

Class participation is a fundamental part of this course. You should do the assigned readings and assignments before coming to the lectures. **You should be prepared to answer cold calls. Please always display your name placard with your preferred name.** Your participation grade reflects the whole semester’s work, and your grade will not vary if you miss one session due to illness. Participation grades are primarily based on participation in class, however, productive participation in canvas discussion boards may also be rewarded. Participation grades are not returned to students.

Attendance Policy:

You are expected to attend all class sessions. Students should **not** come to class if they are sick. The grading rubric has accounted for the fact that students may need to miss one or two sessions over the course of the semester for illness, recruiting, or any host of other important events.

It is the policy of the Jones School that if you miss more than one of the six classes, your grade will be reduced by one third of a full letter grade per excess absence on a 4.0 grading scale (e.g., from an A to an A-). These grade reductions are in addition to potential class contribution losses associated with missing a class.

Re-Grading Policy:

1. Participation grades are discretionary and are therefore not subject to appeal. Partial credit for incorrect answers on graded assignments is given solely at my discretion and are therefore not subject to appeal. Re-grading requests made 8+ days after an assignment was returned to you cannot be appealed.
2. If you decide to request a re-grade, please make a detailed request for a grade revision in writing within seven days of the assignment being returned to you. Carefully explain why you believe the grade is in error. Please submit a request to my Faculty Support Specialist. Requests for re-grades will result in the re-grading of the entire assignment/exam, not just the question(s) at issue. Please note I am probably, on

average, a stricter grader than my teaching assistant when offering partial credit for wrong answers. Your grade may therefore be significantly lower after re-grading.

Honor Code:

You are expected to always follow the letter and the spirit of the Rice honor code in all your actions throughout the course. You are required to agree to follow the honor pledge on all graded assignments. You may not receive or give any assistance on graded assignments that are outside of the parameters defined explicitly by the course assignments. You may never use or possess any material from past years (quizzes, case reports, problem sets, lecture notes, exams, etc.). Any student who assists you is also in violation. All work in the course is to be completed individually unless otherwise *explicitly* indicated in the assignment instructions. You may not distribute your own notes or class materials to anyone else. On all open book/note exams you are permitted to use any textbook, your own notes, and any materials posted to this course's Canvas page – no other materials are allowed. If any aspect of the honor code is unclear to you at any time it is your responsibility to determine whether your actions are consistent with the honor code.

Audio and Video Recording:

Students may not record audio or video in class under any circumstances.

Cell Phone Classroom Policy:

It is the policy of the Jones School for students to turn their cell phones off during class. Obviously, if something serious is up, talk with me prior to class and keep your cell phone on “vibrate.”

Laptop Classroom Policy:

Please bring your laptop to class. Students may use their laptop in the open position during class for annotating notes and calculations.

Disability Based Accommodations:

Any student with a documented disability needing academic adjustments or accommodations is requested to notify me within the first two weeks of class. Students with disabilities should also contact Disability Resource Center in the Allen Center (<https://drc.rice.edu>). All accommodations and adjustments for assignments and exams must be made prior to the graded assignment's deadline.

Religious Accommodations:

Any student that requires accommodation for the observance of religious holidays should coordinate dates with me during the first week of class. Any accommodations or adjustments for assignments must take place prior to the deadline or due date for that assignment.